

BRINGING BACK GANDHI

A famed Gandhian institution revives its original agenda to preserve the Mahatma's ideology and objectives

■ By Uday Mahurkar

Gandhi is back. No, not the original, but someone who comes as close as possible, in terms of the Mahatma's values and philosophy. He is reputed Gandhian economist Sudarshan Iyengar, 54, who is spearheading the revival of a key Gandhian institution as its vice-chancellor. Iyengar with his team has put life back into the Gujarat Vidyapith, a world renowned university set up by Gandhi in Ahmedabad in 1920. Its aim was to spread his philosophy and is known to have nurtured many a world leader.

In the last few years, however, it has been facing a lot of criticism for encouraging a culture of hypocrisy and turning a cold shoulder to many Gandhian ideals. In the three years Iyengar has been heading the institution, along with Rajendra Khimani, a former agriculture college professor, he has remarkably turned around the university's image and functioning. They have largely restored the Gandhian ideals in the campus and in the 4,000 students across the state's six colleges and schools and numerous centres.

Vidyapith, which has assets of over Rs 500 crore and a corpus of around Rs 80 crore, was founded by Gandhiji with three major objectives in mind. One, training students in life skills like carpentry, ironsmithry, spinning and weaving khadi, animal husbandry and agriculture. Two, character building, and lastly, training people to build a society free of class, caste and religious conflicts. These three goals are the latest additions to the curriculum.

Previously, agriculture, one of the corner stones of Gandhian education, had been withdrawn under the University Grants Commission's (UGC) influence in preference to mainstream education, but an attempt is being

made to include it in the syllabus again.

With an unwavering focus on the Gandhian slogan of 'back to basics', Iyengar and his team have restarted many of the activities that had lapsed after the university came under the UGC in the 1960s. One of the university's functions was to solve the problems of the villagers. It had been part of the syllabus of the Vidyapith's graduate and post-graduate courses, but was removed over a decade ago.

It is now compulsory for students and teachers to visit villages every year for four days. The last tour, led by Iyengar, in October 2007, involved visits by 1,800 students and staff in 700 villages. Under the banner of Gram Jivan Yatra, they went to the poorest of villages and tried to understand and find solutions to the problems of the villagers through the Gandhian way. Once the journey began, the students were inspired and happy to be able to make a difference. Says Jaldeep Thakar, a post-graduate student who was part of the yatra: "Interacting with the village students was a great experience. It is justified that the activity has been made mandatory for all."

The Gramshilpi (village developer) fellowship programme has also been introduced to create and maintain links with the villages. Under this plan, a graduate who signs up for a development project in a village is paid a monthly stipend of Rs 5,000 for two years. Around 15 students had enrolled last year and about 20 students are expected to join this year. The programme is expected to be a boon for those who want to work for rural development. This is applicable for teachers also, as community service has been made compulsory for all.

BASIC WAY: Students of the Vidyapith learning to adapt to Gandhian ideals

